STRATEGY MEMO · COMPANION TO THE CHENNAI WHITESPACE RESEARCH · NOVEMBER 2026

SOVO

Structure review, go-forward plan & YouTube strategy

> “The deck describes six businesses. The next 90 days should prove one loop.”

The short answer: keep the name and the ambition. Cut the sequence down. SOVO's real structure is one flywheel: **Events make the work → YouTube shows the work → Studio sells the talent → revenue funds Originals**. Build that loop in this order, with a numeric gate between each stage. Run **one** YouTube channel, not several.

Based on the "SOVO — Beginning" deck (10 slides) and the earlier 32-page report "Sovo — Chennai Community Ecosystem & Whitespace Research". External figures are cited. Anything marked H is a hypothesis to test, not a fact.

1 · WHAT THE DECK SAYS SOVO IS

The structure as written

SOVO = Society of Visual Originators, positioned as a "creative community" and a "creative planet built by creators, for creators". The deck sets out a *why*, a *vision* and five operating arms:

Layer	What the deck says	What it really is (business type)
Why	For creators who feel alone; corporate people drifting from creative passions; people with stories but no circle.	The **audience**: lapsed and isolated creatives
Vision	Original stories, characters, films, "creative universes", community-driven IP.	An **IP / production house** (long-term)
Community	Events, social media, creator-to-creator links, collaborations, WhatsApp → Discord, a physical "Town Hall", all joined in "SOVO Infinity Scale".	A **community platform** + **venue**
Events	Framework: Viability × Content Creation × Affordability. Worked example: *SOVO Open Mic*.	An **event business**
Creatives	Real, raw storytelling; on-the-ground production over AI; Instagram (shorts, BTS) + YouTube (shows, podcasts, docs, short films).	A **media house**
Studio	Creator-powered production for clients; "Creativity as a Service"; revenue that sustains SOVO.	A **creative agency**

1 · Community platform
WhatsApp, Discord, Infinity Scale

2 · Event business
Open mics, gatherings

3 · Media house
IG + YouTube shows, podcasts, docs

4 · Creative agency
Studio / CaaS client work

5 · IP studio
Characters, films, universes

6 · Physical venue
The Town Hall

O That is **six business types**, each with its own economics, skills and failure modes. None has traction yet. The deck gives no member count, attendance figures, revenue, or order of priority.

2 · THE VERDICT

What's strong, what's broken

Keep: these are genuinely good

- **"Collective Creation: turning shared ideas into meaningful creative projects."** This is the most valuable line in the deck. It is exactly the whitespace the research found: Chennai has no recurring format where non-professionals make things together.
- **The "Why" slide.** "Corporate people drifting from creative passions" is a specific, real, emotionally sharp audience, and it matches the lapsed-creative segment from the research.
- **Human-made over AI-made.** A clear stance that will age well as feeds fill with generated content.
- **Studio as the revenue engine.** This is the most realistic money in the deck. Client production work pays from month one. Tickets and AdSense won't.
- **The name has a lane: *Visual*.** Film, photo, design and illustration. That lane is coherent with YouTube, Studio services and the IP vision. Use it (section 3).

Fix: these will sink it

- **Six arms, no sequence.** Every arm sits at the same priority. With a small team, parallel launch means everything is mediocre.
- **The flagship example is an Open Mic.** The research ranks open mics among the *most saturated* formats in Chennai: at least 4 weekly comedy open mics plus Kommune and Mockingbirds. It also uses the "stage script", where 90% of people watch passively. It contradicts the deck's own "Collective Creation" promise.
- **The event framework optimises for the organiser, not the member.** Viability, content and affordability are all SOVO's needs. There is no circle for **"Do people come back, and do they connect?"** Without it, the framework will keep picking easy, filmable, cheap formats like open mics.
- **"Content Creation" as an event criterion turns attendees into props** unless they're credited and own the work. That is the fastest route to the "Instagram event community" perception.
- **Town Hall and IP universes are year-3 ideas presented as current pillars.** A venue is a fixed-cost trap before revenue exists.
- **Discord.** Outside gaming and tech, Indian users live in WhatsApp. Moving early splits a small community. Stay on WhatsApp Communities.
- **Detail signal:** "COMMUNTIY" is misspelled on a headline slide. Fix it before this deck goes to a sponsor.

The uncomfortable pattern, said plainly

The deck and the request together ("YouTube channel**s**", plural) show the habit you named in your own profile: **stretching wide instead of going all-in**, and **designing the system before shipping the first unit**. Space visuals, "Infinity Scale" and "creative universes" are the fun part. The deciding question is boring: *will 30 people come back to a second SOVO session?* Until that number exists, every hour spent on architecture is an hour not spent getting it.

Two audiences hidden in one deck. Pick the order.

The **Why** slide speaks to **lapsed creatives** (corporate, drifting, no circle). The **Studio** slide needs **skilled working creatives** who can deliver client work. They are different people with different motives: one wants permission and belonging, the other wants paid work and credit. **Recommendation:** lapsed creatives are the community's base. The top ~10% who turn out skilled become the Studio bench. That turns the community into a *talent funnel*, which is a real moat (section 3).

3 · RECOMMENDED STRUCTURE

One flywheel, not six arms

Reorganise SOVO around one loop. Each stage feeds the next and has one job.

1 · MAKE
Events where strangers co-create visual work in 3 hours (*SOVO Makes*)

2 · SHOW
YouTube + Instagram publish the work and the people (credited)

3 · SPOT
Best makers join the paid *Studio bench*

4 · SELL
Studio delivers client projects using the bench (CaaS)

5 · OWN
Margin funds *SOVO Originals*, the first IP

↻ Originals and client work become content (2) and attract new makers (1)

Deck arm	New role in the loop	What changes
Events	**Engine** (stage 1)	Flagship becomes a **visual co-creation** format (60-second film, photo story, zine, poster), not an open mic. The open mic survives as *"The Showing"*, the last 25 minutes of every session, where crews present their work.
Creatives	**Amplifier** (stage 2)	One YouTube channel with 3 series (section 5). Content comes *from* events instead of being a separate production line.
Community	**Memory** (glue)	WhatsApp Community with one announcement group and one group per crew. "Infinity Scale" becomes simple: a public archive of every artefact, credited to its makers.
Studio	**Revenue** (stages 3–4)	Launches once 3+ event episodes exist as a portfolio. Pays creators a published share **H: e.g. 65–70% to creators** .
Vision / IP	**Destination** (stage 5)	The first "Original" is a short film grown from the best event concept of the season. Universes come later, out of what members actually make.
Town Hall	**Deferred**	Partner venues only, until Studio revenue covers 12 months' rent.

Fix the event framework: add the fourth circle

Circle	Question	Open Mic	SOVO Makes
Viability	Can we run it?	✔ Easy	✔ Moderate (needs a facilitator)
Content	Does it produce publishable work?	✔ Performances	✔ Artefacts + a story arc with stakes
Affordability	Covered by tickets?	✔	✔ (₹299 → ₹499 + materials)
Return & Connection (new)	Do strangers leave with people, and come back?	✘ Audience stays passive; already saturated in Chennai	✔ Roles + shared object + showing, and crews persist

I With the fourth circle, the framework picks different events. Treat this as non-negotiable: **no format runs twice unless at least 35% of first-timers come back within 60 days.**

The SOVO moat, rewritten for this structure

1. **Talent funnel.** A Chennai agency can hire freelancers. Only SOVO has watched 300 people create under pressure and knows who is good, reliable and kind.
2. **Session recipes.** Briefs, role cards and facilitation scripts, refined across dozens of editions. They can't be seen from outside.
3. **The archive.** Every artefact, credited. After 18 months it is a visual record of Chennai made by its residents.
4. **The channel.** Episodic proof of the above, compounding in search and recommendations.

4 · HOW TO PROCEED

Phased roadmap with gates

Each phase unlocks only when its gate is met. If a gate is missed, fix or redesign. Don't move ahead.

Phase 0 · PROVE THE LOOP (weeks 1–10: Nov 2026 – mid-Jan 2027)

- Run **SOVO Makes #001–#004**, fortnightly Saturdays, 4–7 pm, 30 seats, at a partner café or co-working space. Visual briefs: 60-second film, photo story, zine.
- Film every edition. Publish **4 flagship episodes + 12 Shorts** (section 5).
- Set up a WhatsApp Community: announcements group + one group per crew.
- Ticket form asks: *"How did you hear about SOVO?"* This is the only attribution you'll have.

Gate to Phase 1: ≥35% of first-timers return within 60 days · ≥80% of seats sold at edition 4 · ≥50% of attendees share their artefact themselves · 4 episodes published on schedule.

Phase 1 · MONETISE THE TALENT (months 3–6: Feb – May 2027)

- Launch the **Studio** with a one-page offer: "short-form brand films made by a crew of Chennai creators". Use the event episodes as the portfolio.
- Form the **Studio bench** from 8–12 standout members. Publish the revenue split.
- Sell **Season 1**: a 6-session paid cohort (₹2,499) for returning members (Trevari's model).
- Add a second format: **Unfinished** (monthly work-in-progress critique) for the bench and serious makers.

Gate to Phase 2: 3 paid Studio projects delivered · ≥20% of alumni buy a season · events break even · YouTube ≥500 subscribers (YPP lower tier[6]).

Phase 2 · SCALE THE SIGNAL (months 7–12: Jun – Nov 2027)

- The first **48-Hour Madras**: crews make short films about a neighbourhood, with a public screening. This is the press and sponsor tentpole.
- **Brand-funded briefs**: a sponsor pays for a SOVO Makes edition and gets co-created content.
- Greenlight **SOVO Original #1**: the best concept from the season, produced with Studio margin.

Gate to Phase 3: Studio revenue covers SOVO's monthly costs for 3 straight months · YouTube ≥1,000 subscribers and 4,000 watch hours (ad-revenue tier[6]) · 150+ distinct makers in the archive.

Phase 3 · OWN (2028 onwards)

- IP development: recurring characters or series from Originals that audiences responded to.
- Town Hall, only if Studio covers 12 months' rent with margin to spare.
- A second city, only if the session recipe works with a facilitator who isn't a founder.

Stop list (effective now)

- Stop presenting six arms as equal pillars. Present the loop.
- Stop planning the Discord move, the Town Hall and the "Infinity Scale" architecture.
- Stop using the Open Mic as the flagship example in decks and sponsor pitches.
- Stop gear and tool research. Shoot the first 4 episodes on what you already own (phones plus one camera), and edit in whatever you already know.

5 · YOUTUBE STRATEGY

One channel, three series, built from events

> **"Channels" plural: no.**
>
> Every channel starts at zero subscribers, zero watch history and zero algorithm signal. Splitting a small team's output across several channels divides the signal YouTube uses to recommend you. Run **one channel called SOVO**, with series organised as playlists. Only consider a second channel if a series clearly serves a different audience *and* the main channel has passed 10,000 subscribers H . Choir! Choir! Choir!, the closest global analogue to participatory-event content, built ~340k subscribers and ~100M views on **one** channel, over 15 years and 630 videos[4]. That shows it works, and how slowly it compounds.

5.1 Why YouTube matters, and why not for ad money

Reason	Reality
Audience size	India is YouTube's largest market, at roughly 460–490M users[1].
Ad revenue	Negligible in year 1. Ad-share needs 1,000 subscribers + 4,000 watch hours (or 10M Shorts views in 90 days). The lower tier needs 500 subscribers + 3,000 hours[6]. **Do not budget for AdSense.**
The real value	(1) **Portfolio** for Studio sales, (2) **acquisition** for events ("I saw the episode, I want to be in the next one"), (3) **inventory** for brand-funded briefs.
Competition	Chennai's big channels are entertainment and comedy: Blacksheep ~3.5M, Put Chutney ~1.3M subscribers[3]. Don't fight them on sketches. SOVO's lane is **real people making real things under a deadline**.

5.2 The series slate

Series	Format	Cadence	Job in the loop
MADE IN 3 HOURS (flagship)	12–15 min episode per SOVO Makes edition. Structure: **cold open on the final reveal** (0:00–0:30) → brief revealed → crews formed by roles → mid-session crisis → The Showing → the finished films and works played in full.	Fortnightly (matches events)	Acquisition + proves the format
SOVO WORKS	The artefacts themselves: each 60-second crew film uploaded standalone, with every maker credited in the title card and description.	4–5 per edition	Members share their own work, which is the growth loop
ORIGINATORS	6–8 min process documentaries on one Chennai visual creator. *Show* how they make, rather than interview talking heads. Subjects drawn from the Studio bench.	Monthly from Phase 1	Studio portfolio + "real storytelling" pillar
48-HOUR MADRAS	A 20–25 min documentary of the sprint + a playlist of every film made.	Quarterly from Phase 2	Tentpole, press, sponsors
Shorts	30–45 s cuts: the reveal moment, "stranger → crewmate" moments, the funniest crisis, best frame. Cross-post to Instagram Reels.	3 per week	Discovery

5.3 What not to make (yet)

- **Full-length event recordings** (e.g. a full open-mic video). They have no narrative hook, so retention collapses after the first act. The deck's "full event for YouTube" plan should become the edited flagship episode instead.

- **A podcast.** Podcasting is crowded and grows mostly from audiences that already exist. Revisit once the channel has 5,000 subscribers. "Unfinished" sessions could become the podcast later.
- **Talking-head "creator journey" interviews.** Every creative community makes them. Process footage beats interviews.

5.4 Language and packaging

- **Speak the way participants speak** (Tanglish or Tamil) and **burn in English captions**. That serves Chennai natives and the non-Tamil migrant professionals who are part of the core event audience.
- **Titles carry the stakes**, not the brand. Write "6 strangers made a film about Madras slang in 3 hours", not "SOVO Makes Episode 3".
- **Thumbnail rule:** one face reacting + the finished artefact. Leave out space-themed brand art. Keep the cosmic aesthetic for the channel banner and intro sting only.

Production system & metrics

5.5 Minimum viable crew (per event)

Role	Job on the day	Job after
Producer / host (a founder)	Runs the session, narrates the brief, keeps stakes visible	Story outline for the edit within 24 h
Shooter A	Wide room plus the Showing, locked off	Media offload and backup the same night
Shooter B (phone is fine)	Follows 2 crews closely: faces, hands, crisis moments	Flags the best moments for Shorts
Editor	(Not present)	Flagship episode in ≤7 days, Shorts in ≤3 days

H Budget roughly **15–25 editing hours** per 12–15 minute documentary-style episode. That is why a fortnightly flagship needs a dedicated editor, not a founder squeezing it in. Rotate a **member editor** each edition with a published credit and fee. That is the Studio bench learning on real work.

5.6 Release consent and rights (non-negotiable)

- A **filming consent line on the ticket form**, plus a "no-film" wristband for anyone who opts out.
- Artefacts belong to their makers. SOVO gets a non-exclusive licence to publish, written into ticket terms in plain language. This is also what keeps "Content Creation" from turning members into props.
- Use only original or properly licensed music. Covers of film songs will draw Content ID claims that route revenue to the rights holder.

5.7 Metrics and the series kill-rule

Metric	Why it matters	Review
Event sign-ups attributed to YouTube (ticket form)	The channel's real job. If it stays at zero after 8 episodes, the content is entertaining but not converting.	Monthly
Average percentage viewed (flagship)	Tells you whether the story structure is working. Watch where viewers drop off.	Per episode
Subscribers gained per video	Shows which series builds the channel and which only gets views.	Per episode
Returning viewers	The YouTube equivalent of the 60-day event return rate.	Monthly
Member shares of SOVO WORKS uploads	The growth loop: makers distributing their own credited work.	Per edition

> **The kill-rule**
>
> After **10 uploads in a series**, compare subscribers per video and event attribution across series. Cut the weakest one and put its hours into the strongest. Don't judge a series on fewer than 10 uploads, and don't keep a weak one past 10 out of attachment.

6 · THE NEXT 90 DAYS

Week-by-week

Week	Events	YouTube / content	Business
1 (now)	Lock partner venue; write brief #001 and role cards	Create the channel (banner, intro sting, 3 playlists). Shoot nothing yet.	Fix deck: loop slide, Open Mic → SOVO Makes, typo
2	20 intercept interviews at existing Chennai events (script in research report, Part 15)	Trailer Short: "We're getting 30 strangers to make a film in 3 hours"	Ticket page with consent, attribution question, ₹299
3	**SOVO Makes #001**	Film it with the 2-shooter plan	—
4	Crew groups active; run the 2-question follow-up survey	Publish Ep 1 + 5 SOVO WORKS + 3 Shorts	Draft Studio one-pager
5	**SOVO Makes #002**	3 Shorts	List 20 target Studio clients (Chennai D2C, cafés, cultural venues)
6	—	Ep 2 + WORKS + 3 Shorts	—
7	**SOVO Makes #003** (₹499)	3 Shorts	Identify the first bench candidates
8	—	Ep 3 + WORKS + 3 Shorts	First 5 Studio pitch conversations
9	**SOVO Makes #004**	3 Shorts	—
10	**Gate review**	Ep 4 + WORKS; first series review (too early to cut)	Decide: Phase 1 or redesign

Five decisions the founders must make this week

1. **Lane:** confirm SOVO is *visual* co-creation (film, photo, design, zine), as the name already says. Yes or no.
2. **Flagship:** replace Open Mic with SOVO Makes as the format you lead with.
3. **Owner per stage:** one named person for Events, one for YouTube, one for Studio. If there are only two founders, Studio waits for Phase 1.
4. **Editor:** who edits episode 1, and are they paid? The channel lives or dies on this one answer.
5. **Kill criteria:** write down the Phase 0 gate numbers now, before the first event, so the result can't be rationalised afterwards.

> **Bottom line**
>
> SOVO's ambition is right, but the order is wrong. The deck builds the planet first. Build one working orbit instead: **make → show → spot → sell → own**. Prove the first step with a return-rate number in ten weeks, and let YouTube be the record of that proof. A separate content brand can wait.

SOURCES

References

Accessed November 2026. The Chennai community evidence (open-mic saturation, the whitespace, return-rate benchmarks, Trevari and Oopar models) is cited in full in the companion report, "Sovo — Chennai Community Ecosystem & Whitespace Research" (72 references).

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